

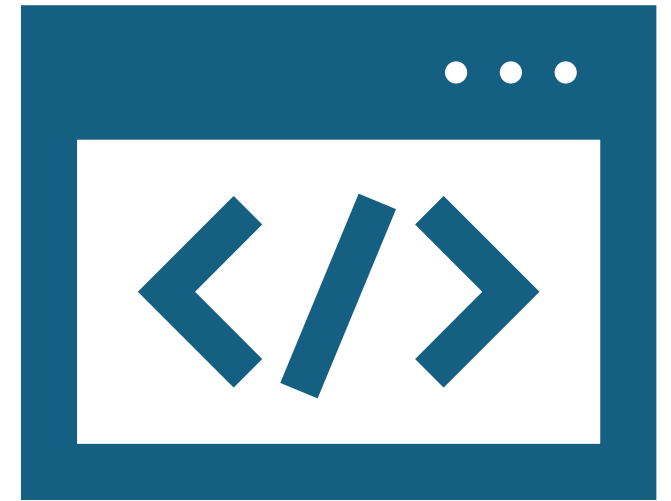


Dangers of the Virtual World

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What is the Virtual World?

- Virtual World can be defined in multiple ways.
- Internet, online communities, social media, VR.
- According to Pew Research Center (2024), “96% of U.S. adults say they use the internet” (p. 2).
- The rate of technology use is rapidly increasing.





Cybersecurity Threats

- What are cyber threats?
- Software posing to be legitimate but contain malware.
- Phishing scams.
- Ransomware.
- It is important to always check for security updates on your system.

Data Collection & Virtual Privacy

- Many governments and popular virtual platforms collect personal and behavioral user data.
- Data abuse is common.
- According to Faverio (2023), “About seven-in-ten U.S. adults (71%) say they are very or somewhat concerned about this” (p. 1).
- Raises concerns of accidental data leaks.



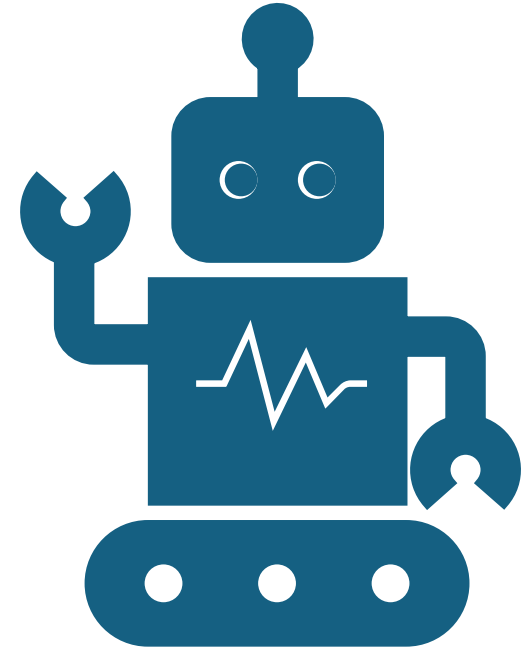


Impersonation & Theft

- Fake or bait accounts make it easy to steal data.
- Modern day AI makes impersonating someone or something easier.
- Innocent people to be blamed.
- Important to not overshare personal information online.

Artificial Intelligence

- AI is used for easy automation to carry out cyber attacks in the virtual world.
- Chatbots can create and spread false information.
- AI ties back to impersonation and fraud.
- According to Atske (2023), “42% [of U.S. Adults] know a deepfake is a seemingly real image, video or audio of something that didn’t occur” (p. 7).



Economical & Financial Dangers

- Financial scams are only rising.
- Data leaks that include personal payment information.
- According to Morgan (2024), “Cybercrime is predicted to cost the world \$9.5 trillion USD in 2024” (p. 1).
- Digital currencies like crypto play a big role in the economical virtual world.



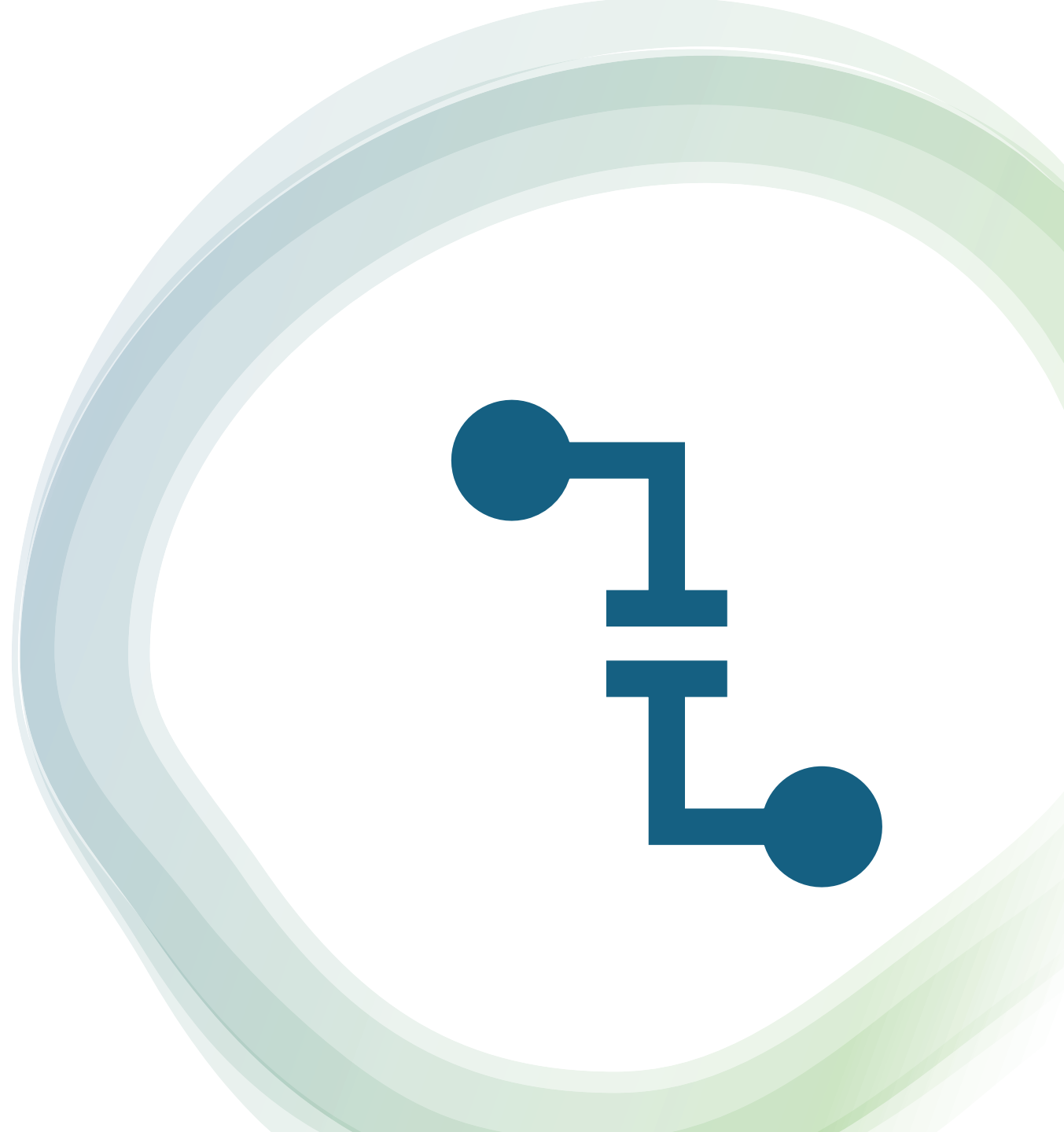
Influence on the Youth

- Teenagers and children are a bigger target for these dangers.
- Phishing and identity risk are common amongst them.
- More likely to download illegitimate software or applications.
- Emphasizes importance of teaching the youth more about cybersecurity.



Psychological Impacts

- Virtual burnout amongst many people.
- Victims of cyberattacks may experience emotional trauma.
- Cyber attackers commonly use manipulation as their tactic.
- Weaken overall trust when in the virtual world.



Ethical Considerations

- Questions about moral use of AI?
- Who is responsible for cyber crimes in the virtual world?
- Consent regarding user data, is it okay to track it?
- Prosecution of those who commit cyber crimes?



General Ways to Keep Yourself Safe

- Educate yourself further about the different kinds of cybersecurity threats.
- Verify sources directed towards you.
- Consistently monitor and update your systems/devices.
- Always enable safeguards when possible (2FA, strong passwords, etc.)



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